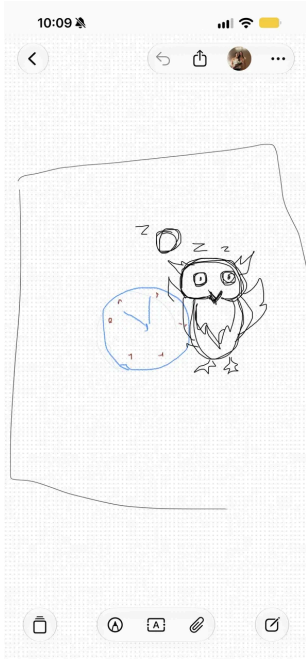


Early Prototype

- From the experience requirements and user testing
 - > we established our role that our technology wanted to play which was to spark a sense of connection between strangers through shared, spontaneous icebreaker
 - > then we established that the artifact was to use drawing as a medium to connect across a distributed environment
 - > for our early prototype our focus was on the look and feel rather than implementation
 - > our design question: how should the drawing game work, should it be competitive, collaborative, or a mix so that people feel a sense of connection between strangers (anonymous or not)
 - > using existing technology with freeform to test formats through telling users instructions such as giving two random people a word prompt and they have to combine their drawings together in one minute
 - > we did testing during week 7 studio and found that people liked a collaborating goal where strangers bond over a hard prompt or bad drawing, they also found that the single one minute round was too short but rather to have rounds to switch between users and that people tend to want to meet the other person after the drawing.
 - > from this, we took the initial recommendation and implemented our functional prototype with sets of prompts and instructions built in. Here we also included our asynchronous feature of a mural/canvas that people can answer from location-specific prompts and see what others have placed there. Our prototype tested a scenario-based scope where a person approaches a tablet and begins putting their thoughts down on their own. When a second person starts using another tablet at the same time, the drawing game is triggered, presenting both users with shared prompts and instructions that turn their individual activity into a joint one.→ the reasoning for this was because the two active ipads that direct two strangers to a shared canvas is to be truly serendipitous, therefore the purpose of the asynchronous message board is the interaction that happens before the serendipitous interaction.
 - > pass to Ruby for findings



Evaluation

Design Objective

Our concept invites spontaneous, low-pressure connection between strangers through shared drawing, both asynchronously and synchronously.

Methodology

Three rounds of testing were conducted in sequence, each investigating a different open design question.

Round	Fidelity	Question Being Tested
Freeform (2 sessions, run first)	Low-fi, Wizard-of-Oz	<i>Look & Feel</i> - does co-drawing with a secret prompt feel collaborative and enjoyable?
Functional prototype (4 sessions, run after, incorporating Freeform learnings)	Higher-fi, real build	<i>Role</i> - does the full flow (message board → serendipitous trigger → Link-Up) make sense, and does being connected to a stranger feel meaningful?
Functional prototype, shared-prompt version (1 session, run after refining onboarding and prompt structure)	Higher-fi, refined build	<i>Look & Feel / Implementation</i> - does a single, shared prompt (rather than two secret, different prompts) still support genuine collaboration, and do the shortened, single-card instructions resolve prior onboarding confusion?

All sessions used a think-aloud protocol, participants explored the interface and narrated their thinking, with moderators intervening only when genuinely stuck. Participants were classmates who don't normally interact with one another, functioning as genuine strangers, with each partner's identity deliberately concealed to preserve authentic serendipity even in a controlled test. Sessions ran during class time, with other classmates present nearby throughout.

Limitations

- Staged, imagined context: sessions used verbal scenario-setting ("imagine you're at a microwave," "imagine you're next to a printer") rather than genuine real-world placement at those locations. Per the Week 8 lecture, evaluation should occur *"in context — an authentic context/location, or as close a simulation as you can reasonably create."* Our simulation was verbal/imagined rather than physically situated; participant behaviour under genuine time pressure or environmental distraction was not fully captured.
- Inconsistent follow-up questions were asked across sessions; some were probed more deeply or differently than others.
- Session 4 was not recorded (interrupted by an incoming phone call) and was reconstructed from memory immediately afterward. It is included at equal weight to other sessions but represents lower-fidelity evidence.
- A system bug in the shared-prompt session caused a mismatch between the instructions ("snail on a train") and the live on-canvas prompt ("snowman in a desert"), confounding clean interpretation of that session's instructional-clarity findings.

Key Evaluation Questions

- How well does the prototype support awareness of the other person's actions?
- Does the serendipitous connection moment feel meaningful, or confusing?
- What breakdowns occur, and what do they reveal about the design?
- How does anonymity affect comfort?

Questions Asked

On the interaction itself

- What was the very first thing you clicked on?
- Did you read the instructions? If you had, do you think you would have understood it?
- Was there anything that confused you, or that you hesitated on?

On working with a partner

- Did it feel like you were working with the other person, or just drawing in the same space separately?
- When did you first notice the other person was drawing? Did it change what you did next?
- Was there a moment you changed your drawing because of something the other person did?
- Did it feel like you and the other person made this drawing together, or like two separate drawings stuck together?

On the experience overall

- How did it feel drawing with a complete stranger?
- How did the transition into collaborative drawing feel?

- Did it feel kind of long, or about the right length?
- Is there anything you wish worked differently?

On the prompts and mechanics

- Did having a different (secret) prompt from the other person make it more interesting, or more frustrating?
- What do you think their prompt/word was?
- What did you think about the prompt you were given on the message board?

On identity and connection

- Would you have preferred meeting that person, or keeping it anonymous?
- Would you want to connect further with the person you were drawing with, e.g. a short voice chat?

On real-world use

- If you were at a printer/microwave and saw this, would you have approached it?
- What's your motivation to do this? (*self-raised by a participant, later asked directly of others*)
- Would you read other people's entries on the board?
- What do you think our domain/concept is about, based on this experience?

On preferences for future design

- Would you prefer an infinite canvas, or the individual boxes?
- Would you prefer all entries to answer the same prompt, or is variety more interesting?

Findings

Interaction

- **Freeform, P1:** noted 60 seconds felt too short to meaningfully contribute.
- **Functional S1:** participant's first action was exploring the message board before adding an entry; struggled to locate the "add" button initially.
- **Functional S2:** *"It was a bit confusing to figure out what I could press... the back button, I didn't realise it was at the bottom."*
- **Functional S4:** explored every visible button before realising tapping into an individual canvas square was required to activate drawing tools.
- **Shared-Prompt Session:** first action was tapping "tap to continue" on the opening screen, described as intuitive; later repeatedly clicked a two-dot presence indicator expecting a menu, with no response.

Awareness

- **Freeform, P2:** on learning her partner could see her drawing live, she began adapting her own contribution, later describing it as *"more collaborative."*
- **Functional S3:** *"Pretty cool to see happening live on the screen,"* despite confusion about the broader flow.
- **Functional S4:** noticed her partner's tree appear mid-session and asked, *"Where did the tree come from? Was it there before?"*, direct evidence of moment-to-moment tracking of a partner's actions.
- **Shared-Prompt Session:** noticed a discrepancy between her instructions and her partner's on-canvas drawing (*"Oh, was I supposed to draw a snowman in the desert?"*), demonstrating active monitoring of her partner's output even under a confusing (bugged) condition.

Coordination

- **Freeform, P2:** finished her drawing well before her partner, reacting with visible surprise, *"Oh my god"* (laughs), direct evidence of a pacing mismatch under open, simultaneous timing.
- **Functional S1:** participant described the 30-second turn structure as workable once explained: *"one person's drawing, and then you can add to it after the 30 seconds is up."*
- **Shared-Prompt Session:** confirmed understanding of turn-locking (*"it kind of locks your screen, so you can't really do anything else"*), and separately raised concern about not being able to exit mid-session if needed elsewhere.

Collaboration

- **Functional S1:** *"I really liked this one better than the first one... for the first one, since we're not really drawing at the same time, I don't really know what to draw."*
- **Functional S3:** *"It felt like we were contributing to one picture"* (asked directly whether it felt like joint work or two separate drawings).
- **Shared-Prompt Session:** *"I think it still felt like we were contributing to one picture. Even with the mix-up, we were still adding things that felt meaningful to the overall picture."* Also described deliberately avoiding editing her partner's contribution directly, out of respect, *"I wouldn't really touch their drawing... that's just my personal choice."*

Experiences

- **Freeform, P2:** *"It's quite good... it's like a new experience... it's really a nice experience."*
- **Functional S1:** *"I think it's a cool idea, especially for the second one [Link-Up]... it's kind of like an old game I used to play... Pictionary."*
- **Functional S2:** *"Ooh I'm so excited"; "I really enjoyed the joint activity, it went really well"; "I love the collaborative side of this one."*
- **Functional S3:** *"No, it was okay"* (re: session length); UI described as *"really cool, very smooth, I really liked the feel of it."*
- **Shared-Prompt Session:** *"I think it was a fun experience... it's fun that you can interact and play with other people."*

Interpretations

- **Functional S1:** initially unsure what was happening; when asked what domain the project addressed: *"I actually don't know. I think there was a domain related to art or something?"*
- **Functional S3:** *"I'm just honestly clueless... I instantly thought I'd made a mistake."* When asked if reading instructions would have clarified things: *"I guess so, if I'm not dumb."*
- **Shared-Prompt Session:** *"Wait, is someone else actually drawing this right now, or is this pre-recorded, like already coded in?"*, questioning whether the "stranger" was real, resolved once confirmed live.

Unwanted Effects

- **Functional S2:** flagged a safety concern regarding anonymity, *"as long as they aren't creepy... like creepy people trying to, you know, target girls or whatever."* Also noted a design risk: incentivising effort so a partner doesn't *"completely derail"* the other's drawing.
- **Functional S3:** flagged real-world time pressure as a risk: *"I might be in a rush if I'm actually in the kitchen, for real."*
- **Shared-Prompt Session:** explicitly connected the lack of an exit mechanism to a realistic negative scenario, *"what if my food is done, but I still have to play this... let's say there's a line behind me as well."*

Additional Findings

Onboarding and Feature-Transition Confusion

- Functional Session 1: the participant did not understand what was happening until directly told by the tester.
- Functional Session 3: the participant assumed an error had occurred when the Link-Up screen unexpectedly appeared, and attempted to navigate back rather than engage, explaining afterward: *"I instantly thought I'd made a mistake... I quickly rushed to the next screen."* When later asked if reading the instructions would have helped, he confirmed: *"I guess so, if I'm not dumb."*
- This indicates the breakdown is one of timing and delivery, not necessarily instructional content, the sudden, unexplained transition induces anxiety that discourages engagement with onboarding at the exact moment it is most needed.

Instructions Perceived as Too Long/Text-Heavy

- Functional S2: *"I didn't read the instructions properly, I was just like 'yeah, yeah, yeah.' No one reads the instructions."*
- Functional S3: skipped instructions entirely, out of fear of having made an error.
- Functional S4: recommended larger, more visual/pictorial instructions.

- Shared-Prompt Session: instructions consolidated to a single card; participants did read and correctly understand them, though a system bug confounds a fully clean conclusion.

UI Issue: Message Board Canvas

- Functional S2: "It looks very isolated, there's a border around everything and it feels far apart."
- Functional S4: attempted pinch-to-zoom (unsupported); described the board as "too individual."
- Shared-Prompt Session: proposed a single, infinite canvas instead of a grid: "I think one big canvas would make it a bit more collaborative... people could draw on top of it... add little cute little doodles."

Synchronous (Link-Up) Preferred Over Asynchronous (Message Board)

- Functional Session 1: *"I really liked this one better than the first one... for the first one, since we're not really drawing at the same time, I don't really know what to draw."*
- Functional Session 2: expressed uncertainty about the standalone message board ("I'm a bit unsure about the 'just me' type of interaction"), stating a clear 100% preference for Link-Up, reasoning she "can do the 'just me' thing at home too."

The Guessing/Competitive Mechanic

- Functional Session 2: *"I love the guessing element... it's like a competitive thing... it's fun."* The participant proposed making this explicitly competitive (each partner guessing the other's word), while flagging a design tension: incentivising genuine effort so partners don't "completely derail" each other's drawing for advantage.
- Functional Session 4: not knowing which prompt corresponded to which message board drawing was described as adding "intrigue" rather than confusion, ambiguity functioning as intended.
- Freeform, Participant 1: found the secret-prompt structure "interesting."

Novel Feature Suggestion, Emerging Directly from Testing

- Functional Session 4: participant independently suggested a tap-and-hold gesture to reveal a message board drawing's originating prompt.
- More colour options, in-turn reaction emojis/text (comparing to Clash Royale), optional photo/webcam sharing (Shared-Prompt Session)

The "Hook" Problem - Approachability of an Unexplained Object

- Functional S2: *"If it wasn't obvious what it was, I'd be thinking someone left their tablet there... make it more colourful... make it enticing to interact with."*
- Shared-Prompt Session: *"Yeah, definitely, I think I'd be intrigued... whenever I'm waiting for my food, I'm always just like, either playing on my phone... if I saw this, I definitely would approach it."*

Anonymity With Growing Openness to Lightweight Alternatives

- Functional Session 1: *"I think anonymous is fun... there's more pressure putting your identity out there."*
- Functional Session 2: indifferent either way, but flagged a safety concern regarding potential misuse by bad actors.
- Functional Session 3: reasoned that the brevity of the interaction made identity unnecessary: *"it's like a few minutes of interaction, so I might not attach to the other person."*
- *Shared-Prompt Session: reaffirmed anonymity preference over webcam/photo sharing, but was notably open to a brief voice-chat feature and independently proposed emoji/text reactions as a lower-pressure middle ground.*

Context and Placement Validation

- Functional Session 3: independently arrived at the concept's intended framing without prompting: *"sort of just do something fun while my food is cooking... my motivation is just to do this to kill time."*
- Functional Session 4: confirmed she would realistically use the tablet specifically while microwaving food, describing the wait as normally "boring."

Pacing Asymmetry (Freeform)

- Freeform, Participant 2: finished her drawing well before her partner, reacting with visible surprise. This directly informed the decision to move from an open, simultaneous drawing window to a fixed, equal-length turn structure in the functional prototype.

Evaluate → Refine

1. Freeform testing revealed general awkwardness and pacing mismatches in simultaneous, open-ended drawing → directly led to the turn-based redesign implemented in the functional prototype.
2. Functional prototype testing (Sessions 1–4) revealed a disorienting, unsigned transition, a canvas discoverability gap, and convergent feedback that instructions were too text-heavy → led to shortened, single-card instructions and a shared-prompt structure.
3. Shared-Prompt testing surfaced three new, highly actionable findings, a confusing presence indicator, no exit/pause mechanism, and a clear user-proposed desire to opt out of Link-Up → next refinement: add an exit/skip option, redesign the presence indicator, and re-test instructional clarity once the prompt-sync bug is fixed.